



Glacial boulders are known as "erratics." Some are small, but they can also be huge.



Clues from the past

When an ice age ends and glaciers disappear, they leave behind lots of clues that the land was once buried under ice. Glaciers carve away land as they flow, forming deep, U-shaped valleys. When they melt, they leave behind huge boulders, called erratics, often made from a type of rock not found locally.



DID YOU KNOW?

Modern humans emerged during the last ice age, living south of the ice sheets. There were also big mammals known as megafauna, including:

- Woolly mammoths
- Woolly rhinos
- Cave bears
- Cave lions
- Giant beavers

Many of the large mammals became extinct just after modern humans arrived.

A blanket of ice

At the peak of the last ice age, some 20,000 years ago, large areas of northern Europe were covered by ice, as well as Greenland and Iceland and parts of the Atlantic Ocean. Europe's mountain ranges—the Alps, the Pyrenees, the Urals, and the Carpathians—were also covered in ice.

Ice age



Today



▲ ICE SHEET

Northern Europe was covered by a gigantic ice sheet during the last ice age.

